

An unlikely champion, a promising future

Lubomir Jancarik's tactical masterclass unfolded at Chennai's new **High Performance Centre for table tennis**, marking a key moment for the sport in Tamil Nadu.

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The World Table Tennis Star Contender in Chennai — featuring nine men and 14 women ranked inside the world's top 50 in singles — produced a new and unexpected men's singles champion in Lubomir Jancarik (**below**), the first Czech to claim the title.

Throughout the tournament, his consistency and tactical intelligence stood out. The 38-year-old does not rely on a single overpowering weapon. **Instead, his strength lies in an all-court game built on balance and control. He possesses a wide variety of serves but favours the backhand sidespin, has a deft and effective short game, and is comfortable in extended exchanges.**

He adapted seamlessly to each opponent's strengths and weaknesses, rarely overplaying and seldom losing control. In many ways, he was the

ultimate disruptor of the home challenge, defeating four Indians en route to the title — Yashansh Malik, Manav Thakkar, Manush Shah and G. Sathyan.

For the Indian contingent, a deep run proved elusive. In singles, none progressed beyond the quarterfinals. While 10th seed G. Sathyan went down to Jancarik in the quarterfinals, qualifier Nithya Mani exceeded expectations by advancing to the women's singles round of 16 before falling to Cheng I-Ching.

In the end, India's standout performance came in mixed doubles, where Harmeet Desai and Yasashwini Ghorpade fought their way to the final before losing to Eduard Ionescu and Bernadette Szocs.

